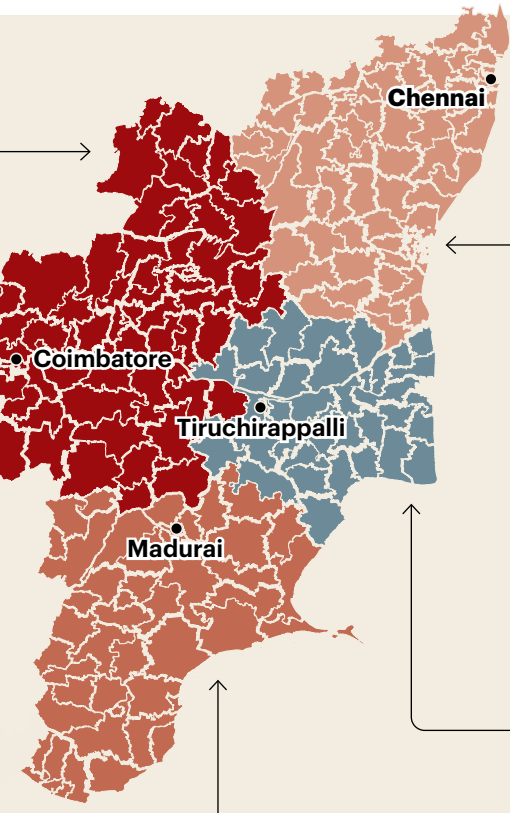


NORTHERN REGION

Chennai, Tiruvallur, Kanchipuram, Chengalpattu, Vellore, Ranipet, Tirupattur, Tiruvannamalai, Villupuram, Kallakurichi, Cuddalore

✪ Vanniyars: 20-25% (higher in northwest belt); Dalits: 18-22%; Muslims & Christians: 10-12%

❖ Urban infrastructure (Chennai floods, transport), education, lack of jobs; caste tensions (Vanniyar-Dalit fault lines); gaps in welfare delivery

2021 results: **85** | **59** | **10**

CENTRAL REGION (Cauvery Delta)

Thanjavur, Thiruvarur, Nagapattinam, Mayiladuthurai, Tiruchirappalli, Pudukkottai, Ariyalur, Perambalur

✪ Vanniyars (in parts): 15-18%; Dalits: 20-25%; MBC and agrarian communities: 20%

❖ Agriculture crisis (Cauvery water); NEET opposition; farmer welfare; hydrocarbon projects

2021 results: **46** | **40** | **6**

SOUTHERN REGION

Madurai, Theni, Dindigul, Sivaganga, Ramanathapuram, Virudhunagar, Thoothukudi, Tirunelveli, Tenkasi, Kanyakumari

✪ Thevars (Mukkulathor): 18-22%; Nadars: 10-12% (strong in south coastal belt); Dalits: 18%

❖ Law & order, caste tensions; agriculture and water stress; unemployment, migration

2021 results: **51** | **36** | **15**

CM Stalin has projected himself as a 'champion of the South', be it in calling a meeting of his counterparts on central devolutions, or "warning" the Centre about the perils of delimitation

as much to do with disrupting the rival AIADMK alliance as widening its own social base. Notable entries in this switchover were the late Vijayakanth's Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK), and former AIADMK grandee and ex-CM O. Panneerselvam (OPS). The DMDK, now headed by the actor's wife Premalatha Vijayakanth, is well past its 2011 heyday when it was the second-largest party in the house, with diminishing returns each passing election. But it does help expand the DMK coalition's vote base and, more importantly, weakens any Opposition consolidation in this regard. The seat-sharing formula has generated some unease within the alliance, especially since the DMDK has got more seats than old allies like the Left parties and the Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK). But, as political analyst Mudhalvan says, "The alliance does have its differences, but on the ground, I feel it is united and working well. This has helped it pin the rival AIADMK-BJP front on controversial issues like delimitation, which is now making headlines."

The Big Bets

Which is exactly what Stalin would be hoping for. The CM, of late, has become a 'champion of the South', be it in calling a meeting of the chief ministers of the states on central devolution and state finances, or "warning" the Centre about the perils of delimitation. In the poll campaign, though, he's taken on the role of elder statesman, leaving the on-ground, tit-for-tat battles to son and deputy CM Udayanidhi and the second rung of the DMK. If there is one area where the DMK seems decisively ahead of rivals, it is in organisational preparation. The party launched the 'Oraniyil Tamil Nadu (Tamil Nadu as one entity)' campaign well in advance, aiming to expand the membership drive and build booth-level networks. Stalin had set ambitious targets on this, pushing the cadre into early election mode. This also helped the party identify weak pockets, negotiate alliance adjustments, and sharpen campaign messaging.

The DMK has also been very active on social media, with the CM himself leading the charge. The makeover even extends to the party symbol—reports have it that the yellow in the 'Rising Sun' is much brighter nowadays to align with the preferences of GenZ youth.

All this ostensibly puts the DMK in a markedly strong position. If the vote transfers work effectively, its rainbow coalition could be at an advantage. But if the disaffection among partners affects ground mobilisation, and the TVK cuts into key segments, the race could tighten considerably.